

Primary Source Reading 2: Spencer's Evolutionary Standard of Conduct

Philosophy Honors: Ethics / Lesson 1.07 — Does Evolution Explain Morality? From Herbert Spencer, The Data of Ethics, Chapter II (1879)

Before you read: This reading is supplementary to the Darwin excerpt — Spencer takes the evolutionary account of behavior a step further than Darwin does, and in a direction Darwin himself never claimed. Where Darwin explains why moral feelings would arise, Spencer argues that the evolved, better-adjusted forms of conduct simply *are* what we mean by “good conduct.” Watch for the exact sentence where evolutionary description turns into moral endorsement — that move is the target of this lesson’s central objection.

The Evolution of Conduct

We have become quite familiar with the idea of an evolution of structures throughout the ascending types of animals. To a considerable degree we have become familiar with the thought that an evolution of functions has gone on *pari passu* with the evolution of structures. Now, advancing a step, we have to frame a conception of the evolution of conduct, as correlated with this evolution of structures and functions.

These three subjects are to be definitely distinguished. Obviously the facts comparative morphology sets forth, form a whole which, though it cannot be treated in general or in detail without taking into account facts belonging to comparative physiology, is essentially independent.

Self-Maintenance and Race-Maintenance

Self-preservation in each generation has all along depended on the preservation of offspring by preceding generations. And in proportion as evolution of the conduct subserving individual life is high, implying high organization, there must previously have been a highly-evolved conduct subserving nurture of the young... Mankind exhibit a great progress of like nature. Compared with brutes, the savage, higher in his self-maintaining conduct, is higher too in his race-maintaining conduct. A larger number of the wants of offspring are provided for; and parental care, enduring longer, extends to the disciplining of offspring in arts and habits which fit them for their conditions of existence.

In tracing up the evolution of conduct, so that we may frame a true conception of conduct in general, we have thus to recognize these two kinds as mutually dependent. Speaking generally, neither can evolve without evolution of the other; and the highest evolutions of the two must be reached simultaneously.

Beyond the Struggle for Existence

To conclude, however, that on reaching a perfect adjustment of acts to ends subserving individual life and the rearing of offspring, the evolution of conduct becomes complete, is to conclude erroneously... The multitudinous creatures of all kinds which fill the earth, cannot live wholly apart from one another, but are more or less in presence of one another—are interfered with by one another. In large measure the adjustments of acts to ends which we have been considering, are components of that “struggle for existence” carried on both between members of the same species and between members of different species; and, very generally, a successful adjustment made by one creature involves an unsuccessful adjustment made by another creature.

From “Highly-Evolved” to “Good”

That which in the last chapter we found to be highly-evolved conduct, is that which, in this chapter, we find to be what is called good conduct; and the ideal goal to the natural evolution of conduct there recognized we here recognize as the ideal standard of conduct ethically considered.

The acts adjusted to ends which, while constituting the outer visible life from moment to moment, further the continuance of life, we saw become, as evolution progresses, better adjusted, until finally they cover the whole of life with a complete adjustment of acts to ends.

After you read: Compare this reading to the Darwin excerpt directly, and notice how much groundwork Spencer builds before making his crucial move. He first establishes, uncontroversially, that self-maintaining conduct and race-maintaining conduct both become more elaborate as organisms evolve. He then observes, also fairly uncontroversially, that the struggle for existence means one creature’s successful adjustment often comes at another’s expense. It is only in the final passage that the identification happens: “highly-evolved conduct” quietly becomes “good conduct,” and the “ideal goal” of natural evolution becomes the “ideal standard of conduct ethically considered.” Darwin traced a mechanism for how moral feelings would arise and stopped there. Spencer takes the additional step of declaring the evolutionary endpoint itself to be the standard of moral goodness — which is precisely what this lesson calls the naturalistic fallacy: moving from a description of what evolution selects for to a claim about what is morally good. For your short analysis, use this passage as your example of evolutionary ethics overreaching, and contrast it with what Darwin’s more modest, purely descriptive account actually establishes.